🎓 Graduation requirements

Online version

Duration and credits

A PhD thesis typically takes **3–4 years** to complete.

The degree requires **30 ECTS** of studies. See the Curriculum.

Article-based dissertations: university rules

Under the current Åbo Akademi University regulations, an article-based doctoral dissertation typically consists of **2–3 scientific articles**. A licentiate dissertation must include **at least one article**. Doctoral programmes may also provide programme-specific guidance.

The following can count as scientific articles:

- published articles;
- articles accepted for publication;
- unpublished manuscripts that have undergone peer review or been accepted for publication; and
- unpublished manuscripts submitted for peer review.

The articles form the main scientific contribution of the dissertation. The appropriate number depends on their scope, scientific significance and quality, the publication platform, and the doctoral researcher's individual contribution to co-authored work.

At least **one article must be accepted for publication**. In exceptional cases, the Head of Department may approve submission with fewer articles than normally recommended if the scope and quality are sufficient.

Preliminary examiners will pay particular attention to manuscripts that have not yet been accepted for publication.

Programme recommendations

The programme recommends judging a thesis by the quality and contribution of the work rather than by article count alone.

- A typical thesis contains **two high-quality papers**, with the doctoral researcher as **first author on at least one**.
- At least **50% of the included work** should be published or accepted.
- The supervisor and head of subject decide when the thesis is ready for preliminary examination.
- The head of department grants permission for the public defence on the basis of the preliminary examiners' statements.
- For every manuscript included in the thesis, the doctoral researcher's contribution should be described precisely. List concrete contributions such as data generation, analysis, writing, and relevant figure panels rather than using broad statements. Use the programme template signed by the supervisor.

Full regulations

- 📄 ÅAU Regulation on Doctoral Studies (PDF)

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